

Symbian Horizon

An application publishing platform supported by the Symbian Foundation, that provides assistance to app developers to be available by October.



Radio Gaga

Web radio services and music industry made peace recently. Former agrees to pay 25 percent of revenue or pay a per-stream rate of 0.08 whichever is greater.



Handle without care

Phones are some of the world's most used and abused gadgets. Unfortunately, most of them are so delicate that you need to be careful with them. With the latest 'rugged' phone from Nokia, you won't have to worry about any of those things. The phone has IP54 certification, which indicates it's completely dust and water resistant. Nokia has even enhanced its shock protection.

There are several videos online of the phone enduring torture, including being completely submerged – not only in water, but even jelly and beer. All the while the phone was switched on and received calls! After getting drenched in beer, it could act moody, call random people, and not make phone calls in a straight line, but it certainly functions. It was even shot with a paintball gun. And those that have been hit with a paintball pellet will tell you that it hurts like hell even through protective overalls and is known to chip wood with the impact. The phone has steel parts in the body that are sealed all through. The back cover opens only by unbolting a metal screw lock. In keeping

with the rugged nature of the phone, the 3720 comes with an LED torch light that also doubles up as a flash for its 2-MP camera. The phone is a Symbian series 40 device, that comes with a 2.2-inch QVGA TFT display, FM and Bluetooth. What about looks? The lineage that the phone comes from dates back to the 5140. The phones from this rugged bloodline have always been above average in the looks department. And the 3720 does not disappoint. On the negative side, however, the phone doesn't have 3G. Reportedly the phone will retail for around

Reliance to send novels via SMS

We've all heard of audio books, ebooks and more recently 'classic' old school paper ones. But the latest innovation to hit the written word is SMS books! That's right, Reliance Communications plans to dole out SMS novels in India. Perhaps this move is in light of the dearth of data-enabled cell phones in the country, and the small fraction actually connected to data services. The novel *Deaf Heaven* will be sent to subscribers through a total of 90 SMSs

over a period of thirty days. The pricing is affordable; subscribers will be charged Rs. 30 for the full book, which works out to an affordable Re. 1 per day. The only trouble is that while reading an actual book we tend to keep it aside when we want, not when there are no more pages continuing the story. So in this SMS delivery mechanism there should be a way for subscribers to ask for the next set of messages, since most people wouldn't want to wait until the next day to continue the story.

Reliance also plans to make the book available as an *adult* audio book. The audio book would be available on a multimodal number where

subscribers would be charged Re. 1 per minute. The audio book will have a duration of 60 minutes with a subscription fee of Rs. 30. This is apparently a first for publisher HarperCollins – looking at expanding reach and finding innovative ways of creating synergy through related media. It hopes there will be many more such releases for the Indian

market. The book itself is a story "of optimism over a life-changing weekend, culminating on the day of a total solar eclipse" and is by the award winning author Pinki Virani.

The business of iPhone apps

July marked one year since Apple began allowing independent developers to sell their apps through the iTunes App Store. During this year that passed by, we have witnessed a frenzy from geeks all over the world to

create a variety of applications for the iPhone. But are any of these geeks becoming millionaires selling inane applications such as "Rate a Fart 2.0", which, incidentally, is selling for 99 cents? All logic points towards a firm no. Still that hasn't stopped the App Store's repertoire from reaching well over 50,000 apps and more than 1.5 billion downloads. The base and top of this pyramid consists of applications that cost less than a dollar. One might in fact be inclined to think Apple is running a digital dollar store.

The best seller lists titles such as *GloBall* and *Flight Control* – both games. These are hardly the building blocks of something that can become



as big as an Amazon or eBay. Besides, most veteran app developers around the world are saying that the app store is now very crowded. Getting noticed is therefore becoming even more difficult. There are sites such as **148Apps.biz** that even give app makers tutorials on how to market their applications. Tips include getting your app reviewed on some of the dozens of app review sites that have sprung up, such as **AppScout.com**. Making apps might be serious business or just something that geeks do on the side for fun or popularity. Yet, there are signs that more serious and utility-oriented apps are on their way. For example, the *Quickoffice Mobile Office Suite* that has crept in at the ninety-ninth position on the top 100 list. It's a \$12.99 application for creating, editing and synching documents and spreadsheets. There is also a \$100-million dollar venture capital fund called *iFund*, that intends to "fund market-changing ideas and products that extend the revolutionary new iPhone and iPod touch platform". However, the fund has so far managed to fund only five ventures. Considering the competition from Pre and Android that is expected in the near future, let's hope the enthusiasm of app makers continues undampened.